

03

Map of the Sicilian Families

Dragon, Sveshnikov, and Taimanov: three different answers to development and central control.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will understand what Black is buying in each major family and why the Najdorf is the backbone of this repertoire.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 013 | PAGE 4

Decode: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal*The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.*

LESSON 014 | PAGE 8

Play: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal*The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.*

LESSON 015 | PAGE 12

Decode: Sveshnikov: activity for holes*The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.*

LESSON 016 | PAGE 16

Play: Sveshnikov: activity for holes*The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.*

LESSON 017 | PAGE 20

Decode: Taimanov: flexible development*Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.*

LESSON 018 | PAGE 24

Play: Taimanov: flexible development*Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will understand what Black is buying in each major family and why the Najdorf is the backbone of this repertoire.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Dragon develops the bishop in one move and attacks the center from g7, accepting a sharp race against queenside castling.

DECISION RULE

Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use the g7 bishop, c-file, and tactical exchange sacrifices to attack before White opens the h-file.

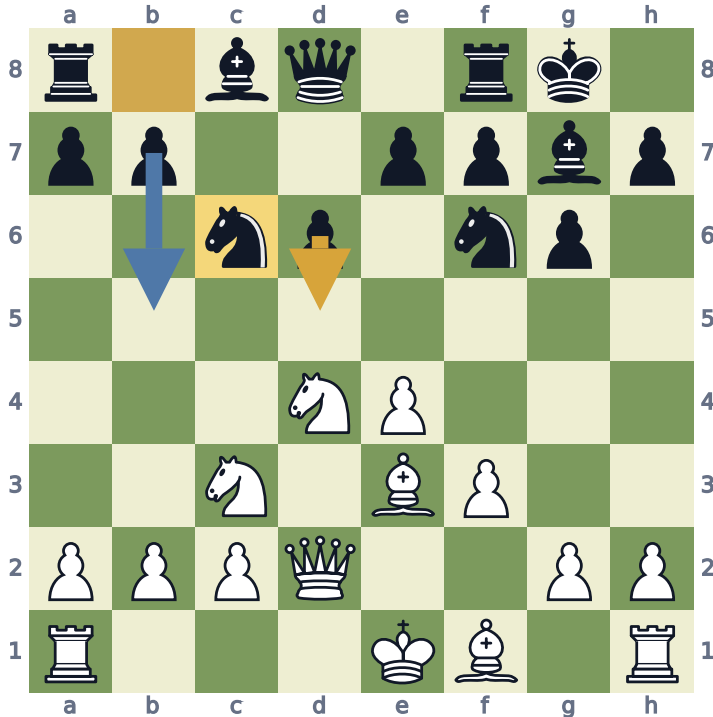
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White builds the Yugoslav setup, castles long, and pushes h4-h5 to strip the king.

MEMORY RULE | The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Dragon develops the bishop in one move and attacks the center from g7, accepting a sharp race against queenside castling.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use the g7 bishop, c-file, and tactical exchange sacrifices to attack before White opens the h-file.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White builds the Yugoslav setup, castles long, and pushes h4-h5 to strip the king.

FAILURE MODE

Playing on the queenside too slowly while White's pawn storm opens lines with tempo.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Dragon develops the bishop in one move and attacks the center from g7, accepting a sharp race against queenside castling.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock? White's resistance is: White builds the Yugoslav setup, castles long, and pushes h4-h5 to strip the king. The line fails as a template when: Playing on the queenside too slowly while White's pawn storm opens lines with tempo.

STORE THIS | The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

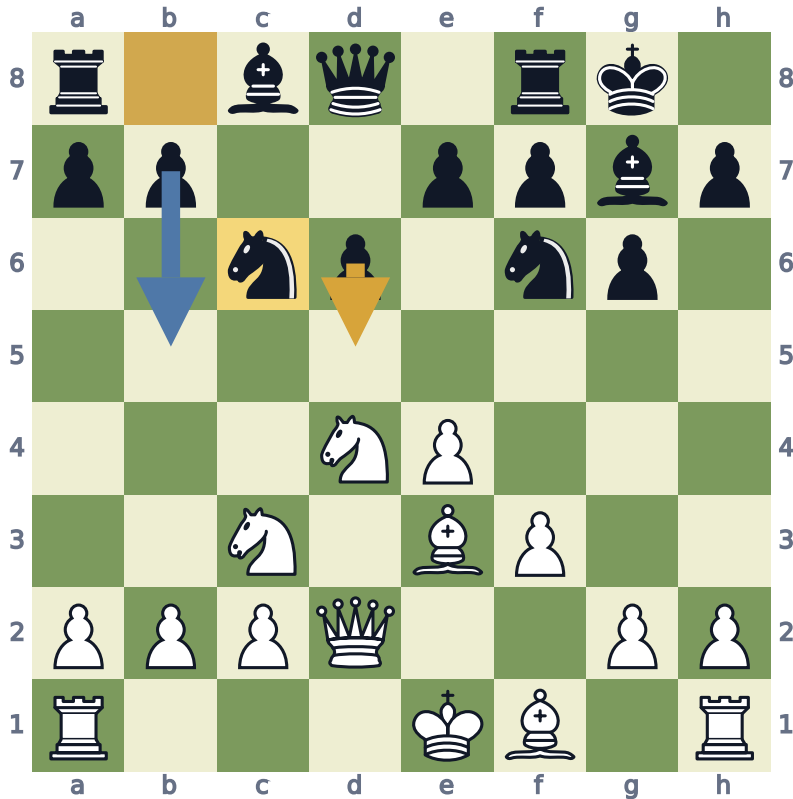
1. The Dragon develops the bishop in one move and attacks the center from g7, accepting a sharp race against queenside castling. 2. Use the g7 bishop, c-file, and tactical exchange sacrifices to attack before White opens the h-file. 3. White builds the Yugoslav setup, castles long, and pushes h4-h5 to strip the king. 4. Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock? 5. Playing on the queenside too slowly while White's pawn storm opens lines with tempo.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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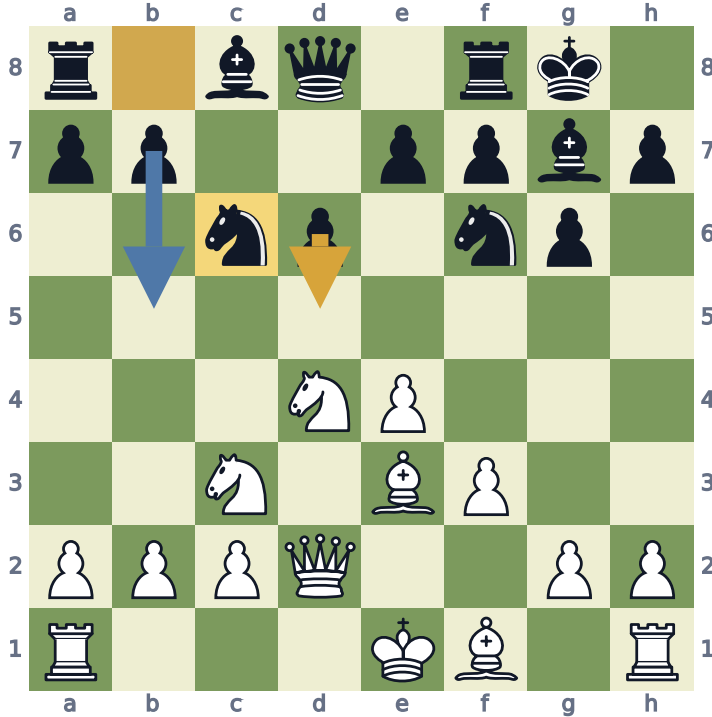
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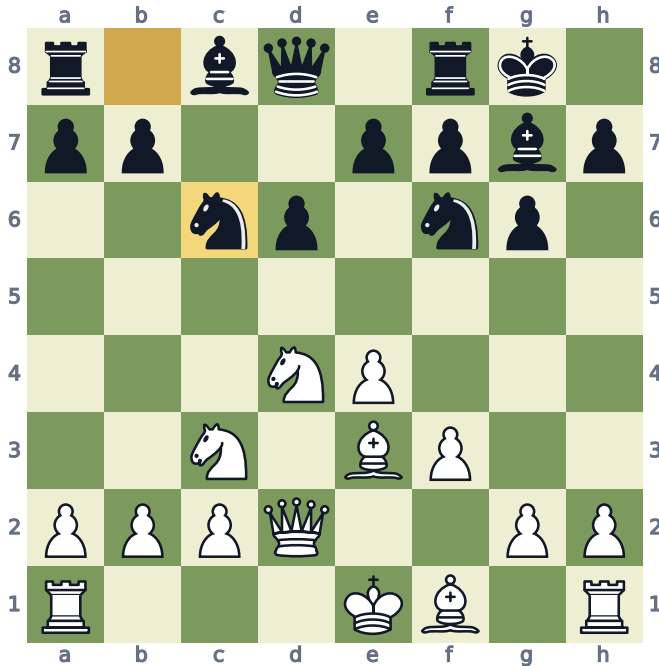
RULE | The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6



- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Dragon develops the bishop in one move and attacks the center from g7, accepting a sharp race against queenside castling.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock? White's resistance is: White builds the Yugoslav setup, castles long, and pushes h4-h5 to strip the king. The line fails as a template when: Playing on the queenside too slowly while White's pawn storm opens lines with tempo.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

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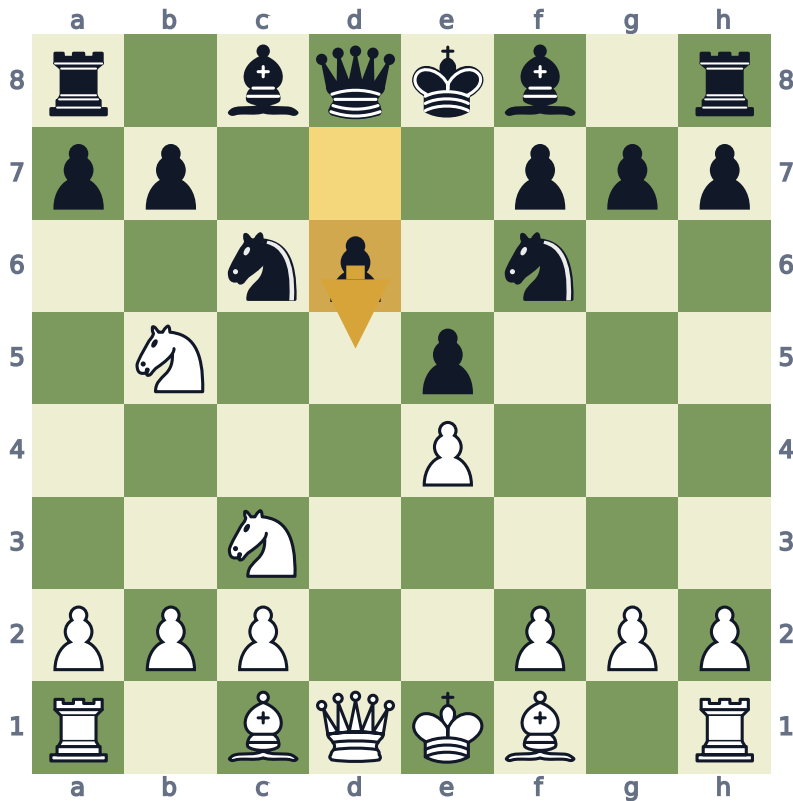
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Sveshnikov: activity for holes

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

...e5 and ...b5 seize space and activity, while d5 and d6 become lasting strategic targets.

DECISION RULE

Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use dynamic piece play and timely ...f5 before White consolidates on the weak squares.

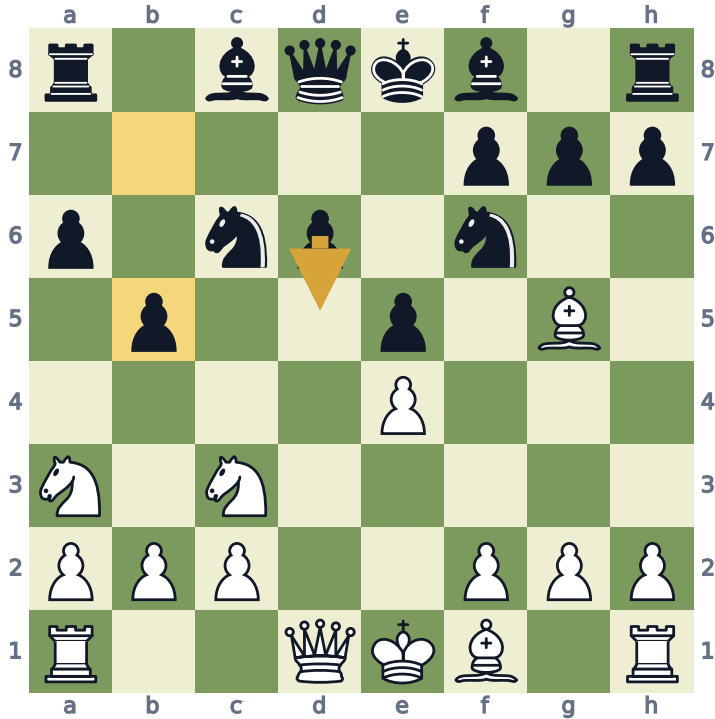
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White occupies d5, pressures d6, and tries to convert structural weaknesses after exchanges.

MEMORY RULE | The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e5 and ...b5 seize space and activity, while d5 and d6 become lasting strategic targets.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White occupies d5, pressures d6, and tries to convert structural weaknesses after exchanges.

FAILURE MODE

Entering the structure without accepting that passive defense will simply lose the weak pawns.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

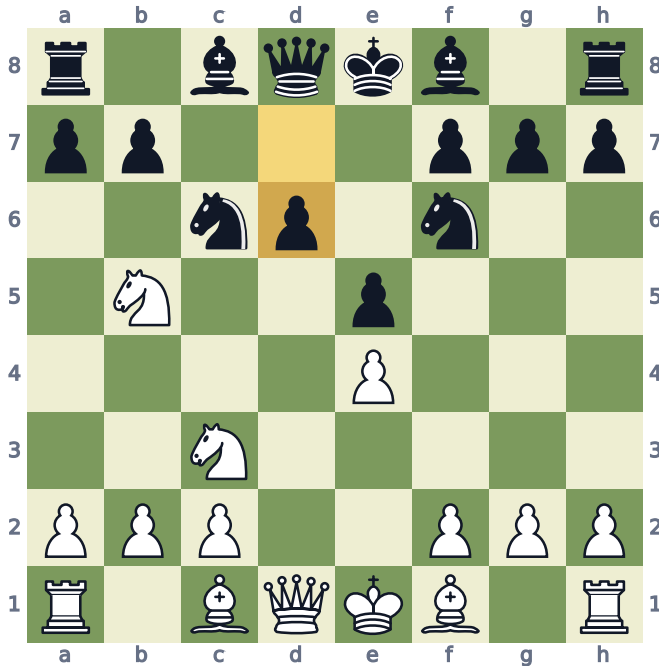
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Ndb5: White reroutes a knight to b5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e5 and ...b5 seize space and activity, while d5 and d6 become lasting strategic targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses? White's resistance is: White occupies d5, pressures d6, and tries to convert structural weaknesses after exchanges. The line fails as a template when: Entering the structure without accepting that passive defense will simply lose the weak pawns.

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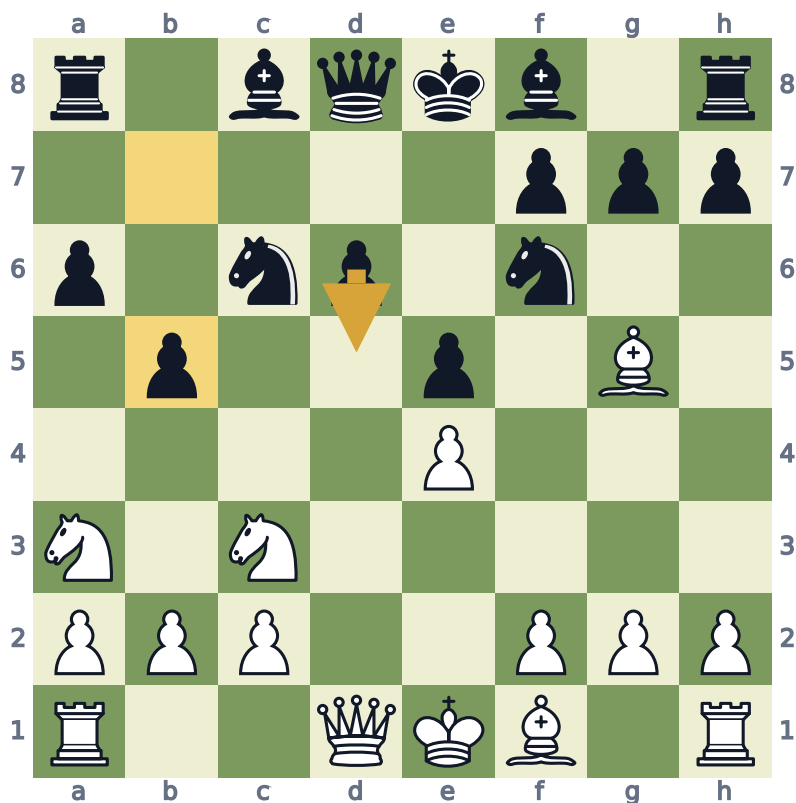
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Sveshnikov: activity for holes



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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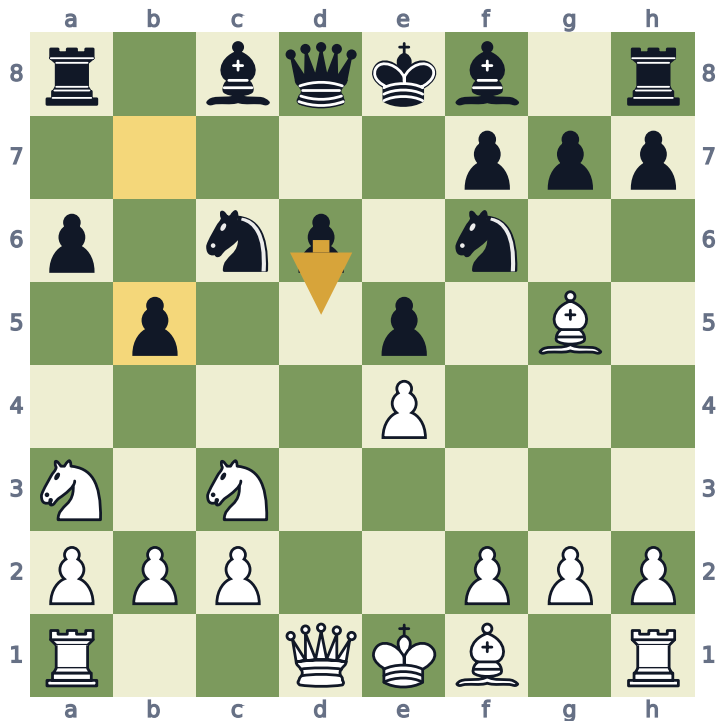
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White occupies d5, pressures d6, and tries to convert structural weaknesses after exchanges.

FAILURE MODE

Entering the structure without accepting that passive defense will simply lose the weak pawns.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

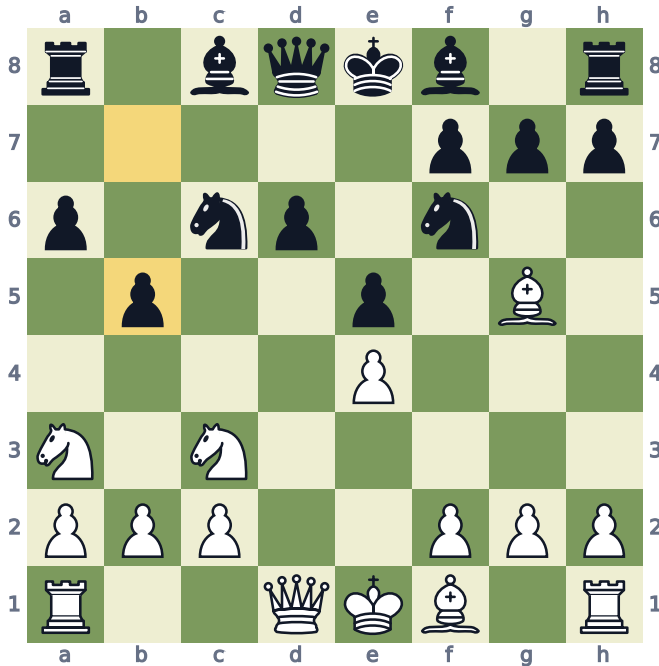
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5



- Ndb5: White reroutes a knight to b5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bg5: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Na3: White reroutes a knight to a3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- b5: Black starts queenside expansion and prepares files or a bishop diagonal.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e5 and ...b5 seize space and activity, while d5 and d6 become lasting strategic targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses? White's resistance is: White occupies d5, pressures d6, and tries to convert structural weaknesses after exchanges. The line fails as a template when: Entering the structure without accepting that passive defense will simply lose the weak pawns.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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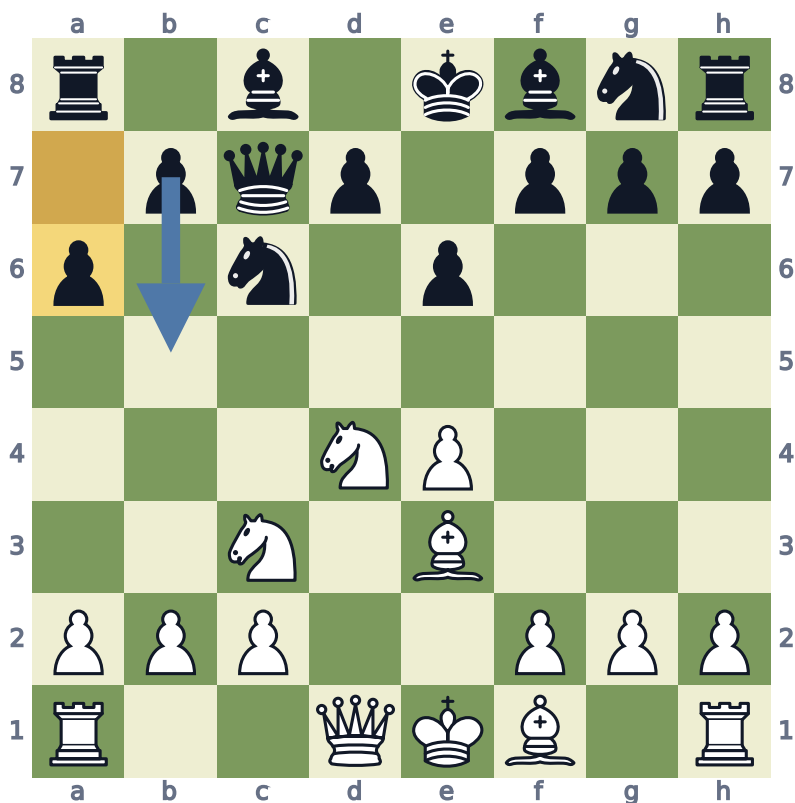
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Taimanov: flexible development



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Taimanov delays ...d6 and develops flexibly, preserving several central structures and move-order tricks.

DECISION RULE

Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Pressure c3, choose ...Nf6 or ...Nge7 intelligently, and use ...b5 or ...d5 according to White's setup.

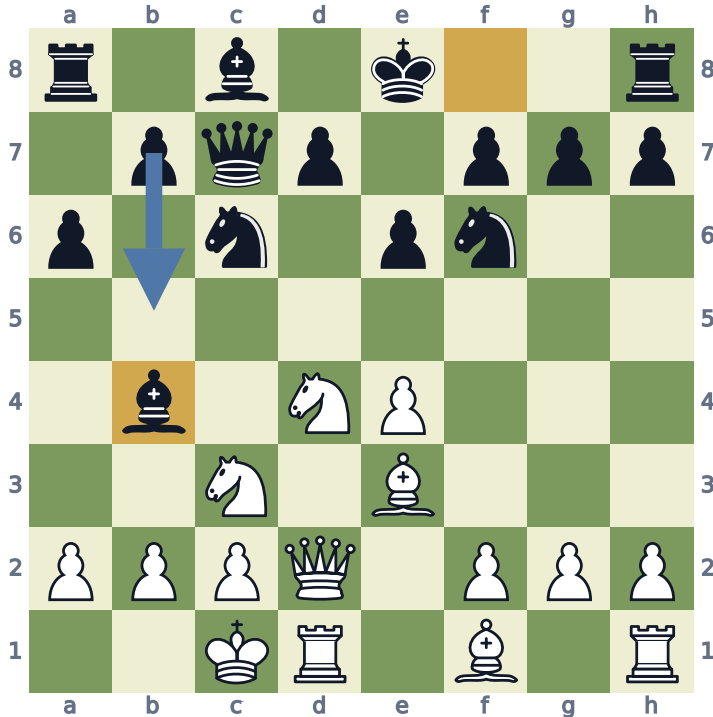
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks fast long castling, f3-g4, or a Maroczy-style bind before Black defines the center.

MEMORY RULE | Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Taimanov delays ...d6 and develops flexibly, preserving several central structures and move-order tricks.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks fast long castling, f3-g4, or a Maroczy-style bind before Black defines the center.

FAILURE MODE

Keeping every option open so long that no piece receives a definite job.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

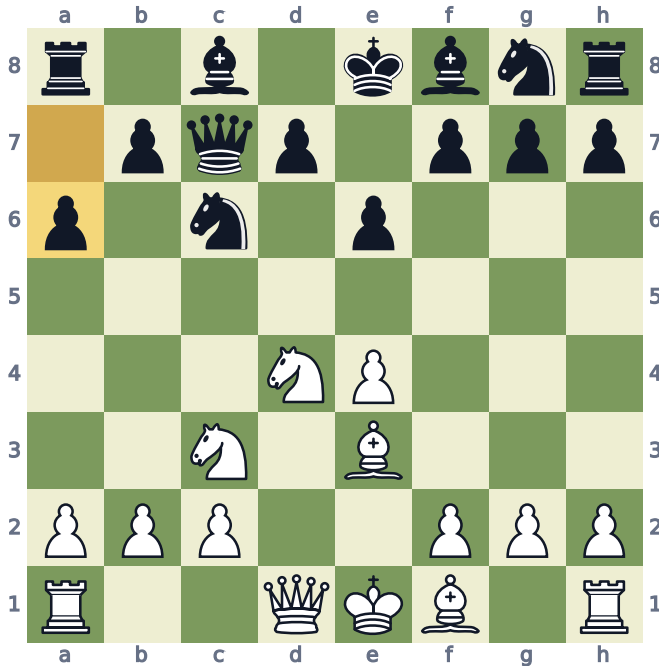
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan? White's resistance is: White seeks fast long castling, f3-g4, or a Maroczy-style bind before Black defines the center. The line fails as a template when: Keeping every option open so long that no piece receives a definite job.

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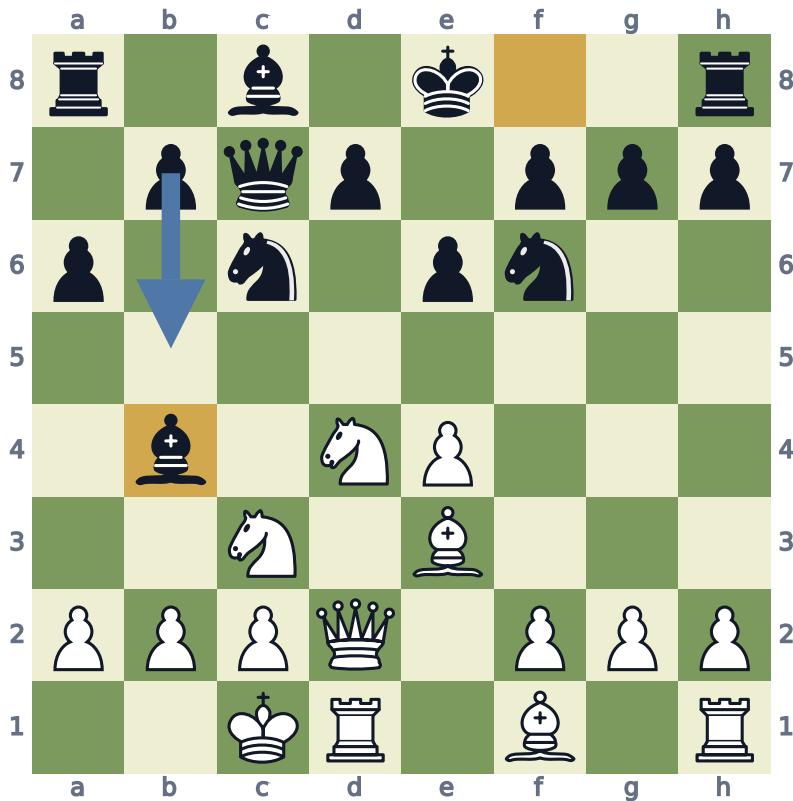
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PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Taimanov: flexible development



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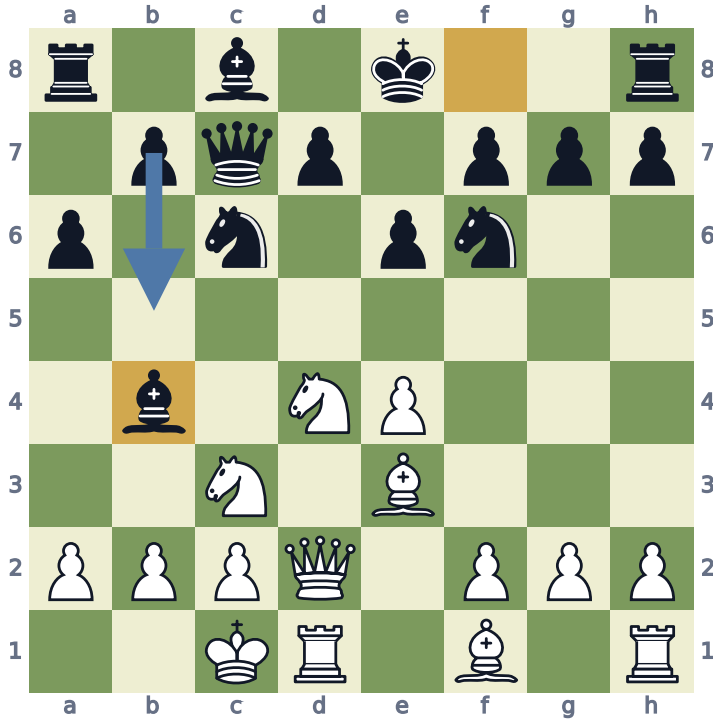
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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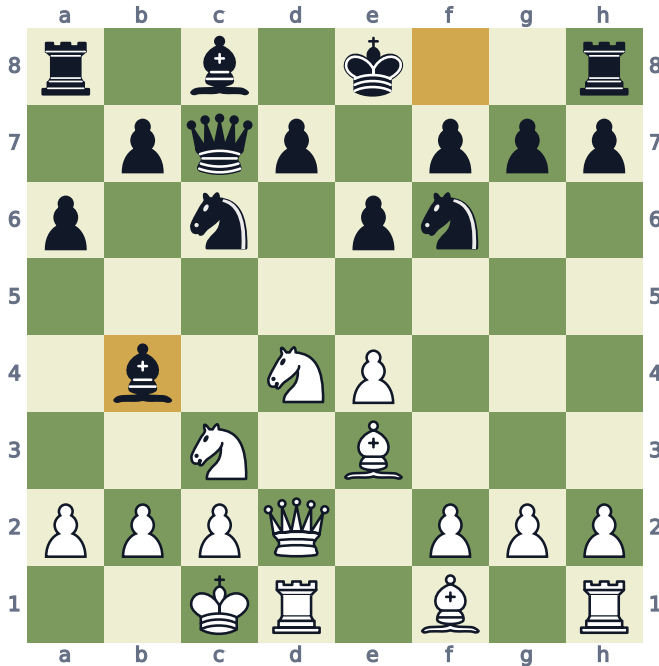
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Bb4: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Taimanov delays ...d6 and develops flexibly, preserving several central structures and move-order tricks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan? White's resistance is: White seeks fast long castling, f3-g4, or a Maroczy-style bind before Black defines the center. The line fails as a template when: Keeping every option open so long that no piece receives a definite job.

STORE THIS | Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The Taimanov delays ...d6 and develops flexibly, preserving several central structures and move-order tricks. 2. Pressure c3, choose ...Nf6 or ...Nge7 intelligently, and use ...b5 or ...d5 according to White's setup. 3. White seeks fast long castling, f3-g4, or a Maroczy-style bind before Black defines the center. 4. Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan? 5. Keeping every option open so long that no piece receives a definite job.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 013 Decode: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal

Prompt: Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock?

Recall: *The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.*

LESSON 014 Play: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal

Prompt: Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock?

Recall: *The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.*

LESSON 015 Decode: Sveshnikov: activity for holes

Prompt: Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses?

Recall: *The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.*

LESSON 016 Play: Sveshnikov: activity for holes

Prompt: Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses?

Recall: *The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.*

LESSON 017 Decode: Taimanov: flexible development

Prompt: Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan?

Recall: *Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.*

LESSON 018 Play: Taimanov: flexible development

Prompt: Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan?

Recall: *Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.*

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Dragon: speed and the long diagonal

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6

Decision: Whose forcing attack lands first, and which exchange changes the race clock?

Memory: The Dragon is a race; count forcing moves, not attractive moves.

CARD 2

Sveshnikov: activity for holes

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5

Decision: Does Black's next active move create a concrete threat before White fixes the weaknesses?

Memory: The Sveshnikov trades squares for time; spend the time immediately.

CARD 3

Taimanov: flexible development

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

Decision: Which white setup has appeared, and which flexible option should now be converted into a concrete plan?

Memory: Flexibility is useful only when you know the trigger that ends it.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
013 Decode: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
014 Play: Dragon: speed and the long diagonal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
015 Decode: Sveshnikov: activity for holes	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
016 Play: Sveshnikov: activity for holes	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
017 Decode: Taimanov: flexible development	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
018 Play: Taimanov: flexible development	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.